Stephen was by now over sixty, Henry barely twenty. The young man agreed to the terms, and the two men signed the Treaty of Wallingford in January of 1154, a mere year after Henry's arrival in England.

For ten months, Stephen governed England as undisputed king: "At this time," writes William of Newburgh, "he . . . began to rule as if for the first time." But in October, presiding over a church council in Kent, he grew violently ill with "colic" and "infected piles"—probably amoebic dysentery, a constant scourge in a world with too much standing water and not enough soap. He took to his bed and died a few days later.[6]

Henry, in Normandy at the time of Stephen's death, was delayed by bad weather and logistics; but he finally arrived on English shores on December 7, to the cheers of the battered populace. "They had experienced the misery of the previous reign, under which so many evils had sprouted," William of Newburgh says, "and they hoped for better things from the new ruler." He and Eleanor were crowned king and queen of England on December 19, at Westminster Abbey. Within a week, Henry had begun to sweep the muck out of England's war-soiled halls.[7]

It was a happy coincidence between a country's need and a monarch's personality. Henry was by nature unable to sit still. His invasion of England at the age of fourteen was merely the first symptom of an energy that overflowed, his entire life, onto everyone around him. "If the king has promised to spend the day anywhere," wrote his secretary Peter of Blois,

> you may be sure that he will start off early in the morning. . . . You may see men running about as if they were mad, urging on the pack-horses, driving chariots into one another, and everything in a state of confusion. . . . He never sits down except when on horseback or at meals. On a single day, if necessary, he travels a journey of four or five days. . . . He does not loiter in his palace like other kings, but hurrying through the provinces he investigates what is being done everywhere.[8]

He was, always, active. He heard Mass every day, but found it so impossible to sit still that he whispered orders to his officials all during the service and, when silence was unavoidable, drew pictures. His favorite priests were those who were fastest at chanting the Mass, so that he could get on to the next thing. When his intentions were blocked, he flew into immediate and prodigious rages, once ripping off his clothes and hurling them around the room in a fury at some dereliction of duty by his constable. He was constantly traveling and often away from his wife's bedroom; but despite this, Eleanor had given him a son before the coronation and was again pregnant, in what